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Martha, Mary and Lazarus

A family in Bethany whom Jesus loved, and whose brother he called out of the grave.

Martha, Mary and their brother Lazarus lived in Bethany, just outside Jerusalem, and their home was a place of welcome for Jesus. John says simply that "Jesus loved Martha, and her sister, and Lazarus." Luke shows Martha busy serving and Mary sitting at Jesus' feet. John tells how Lazarus died, how Jesus wept with the sisters, and how he called Lazarus out of the tomb after four days. Days later Mary poured costly ointment on Jesus' feet. This family shows friendship with Jesus in ordinary life, in grief, and in worship.

At a glance

<i>Names</i>	Martha; Mary; Lazarus, a Greek form of Eleazar
<i>Family</i>	Two sisters and their brother (John 11:1-2)
<i>Home</i>	Bethany, under two miles from Jerusalem (John 11:18)
<i>When</i>	c. AD 29-30
<i>Known for</i>	Welcoming Jesus; Lazarus raised; Mary's anointing
<i>Key people</i>	Jesus, Thomas, the mourners, Caiaphas, Judas Iscariot
<i>Main passages</i>	Luke 10:38-42; John 11:1-12:19

"Jesus said unto her, I am the resurrection, and the life: he that believeth in me, though he were dead, yet shall he live:"

John 11:25, KJV

The life of Martha, Mary and Lazarus

Dates are approximate (AD), with the crucifixion c. AD 30 (on the AD 33 view, add three years). Luke gives no date and does not name the village.

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| <p>c. AD 29
<i>A village visit</i></p> | <p>● Martha welcomes Jesus
Mary sits at his feet while Martha is "cumbered about much serving." Jesus says Mary has chosen "that good part." <i>Luke 10:38-42</i></p> |
| <p>c. AD 30
<i>Winter</i></p> | <p>● Lazarus falls sick
The sisters send word to Jesus beyond the Jordan. He says the sickness is for God's glory and stays two more days. <i>John 10:40; 11:1-6</i></p> |
| <p>c. AD 30
<i>Four days later</i></p> | <p>● Martha meets Jesus
Jesus tells her, "I am the resurrection, and the life." She confesses him as the Christ, the Son of God. <i>John 11:17-27</i></p> |
| <p>c. AD 30
<i>The same day</i></p> | <p>● Jesus weeps
Mary falls at his feet with the same words as Martha. Seeing the mourners weeping, Jesus groans in spirit and weeps. <i>John 11:28-37</i></p> |
| <p>c. AD 30
<i>The same day</i></p> | <p>● Lazarus comes forth
The stone is taken away, and Jesus cries, "Lazarus, come forth." The dead man walks out in graveclothes. <i>John 11:38-44</i></p> |
| <p>c. AD 30
<i>Soon after</i></p> | <p>● The council plots
Many believe, but the council, led by Caiaphas, plans Jesus' death, and Jesus withdraws to Ephraim. <i>John 11:45-54</i></p> |
| <p>c. AD 30
<i>Six days before
Passover</i></p> | <p>● Supper and anointing
Martha serves and Mary anoints Jesus' feet with spikenard. Crowds come to see Lazarus, and the priests plot to kill him too. <i>John 12:1-11</i></p> |

Key activities

Matthew 26:6–13 and Mark 14:3–9 tell of a woman who anoints Jesus' head at the house of Simon the leper in Bethany. Most readers think this is the same event as John 12, where the woman is Mary. Luke 7:36–50 is a different anointing, in Galilee.

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- I Martha opened her home.** She received Jesus into her house as a guest. *Luke 10:38*

 - 2 Mary sat at Jesus' feet.** She took the place of a disciple and listened to his word. *Luke 10:39*

 - 3 Martha spoke her frustration.** "Lord, dost thou not care that my sister hath left me to serve alone?" Jesus answered her gently: "one thing is needful." *Luke 10:40–42*

 - 4 The sisters sent for Jesus.** They brought their need straight to him and trusted his love. *John 11:3*

 - 5 Martha confessed her faith.** In grief she still said, "I believe that thou art the Christ, the Son of God." *John 11:21–27*

 - 6 Mary brought her tears.** She fell at Jesus' feet and wept, and Jesus wept with her. *John 11:32–35*

 - 7 Lazarus was raised.** At Jesus' command he came out of the tomb, and Jesus said, "Loose him, and let him go." *John 11:43–44*

 - 8 Many believed.** The miracle led many to put their faith in Jesus. *John 11:45; 12:11*

 - 9 Martha served again.** At the supper in Bethany she served, as she had before. *John 12:2*

 - IO Mary anointed Jesus.** She poured a pound of spikenard on his feet and wiped them with her hair. Jesus said, "against the day of my burying hath she kept this." *John 12:3–8*

 - II Lazarus became a target.** Because his new life drew people to Jesus, the chief priests planned to kill him as well. *John 12:10–11*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names this family.

Old Testament

Echo: 1 Kings 17:17–24;	Elijah and Elisha raise dead sons
2 Kings 4:32–37	
Echo: Ezekiel 37:12–14	God opens graves and gives his Spirit

New Testament

Luke 10:38–42	Martha serves and Mary listens
John 11:1–12:19	Lazarus raised; the council plots; Mary anoints Jesus
Matthew 26:6–13; Mark 14:3–9	The anointing at Bethany, told as a memorial
Luke 16:19–31	A different Lazarus, the beggar in a parable
Echo: 1 Thessalonians 4:13–14	Not sorrowing as those with no hope
Tradition	Legends take Lazarus to Cyprus or Provence; merging Mary with Magdalene is unscriptural

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Martha and Mary each say to Jesus when he arrived (John 11:21, 32)?
2. *Understand:* Jesus knew he would raise Lazarus, yet he wept (John 11:35). What does that show about him?
3. *Apply:* Are you more like Martha, busy serving, or Mary, sitting to listen? What would one step toward the other look like?
4. *Apply:* Martha believed in the middle of grief. How could you come alongside someone grieving this week?